

Job & Internship Search Guide

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When Should I Start?

Most searches take 3–6 months (this includes internships). In competitive job markets, it can take 6-9 months, so starting early is beneficial. Please note that the following timeline varies depending on the specific industry or role. Research your intended industry’s hiring timelines at least 6 months before you want to apply.

SAMPLE TIMELINE

Timeframe	Key Actions
<i>9–12 Months Out</i>	• Explore careers • Research hiring timelines • Join a student organization to develop a network
<i>6–12 Months Out</i>	• Build/update resume & LinkedIn profile • Attend events • Start networking
<i>4–6 Months Out</i>	• Apply • Follow up • Continue networking • Practice interviewing
<i>1–2 Months Out</i>	• Prep for interviews & offers
<i>Ongoing</i>	• Keep learning • Keep applying • Grow skills • Maintain Network

Defining Your Career Goals

Landing the right job or internship starts with knowing your interests, skills, values, and ideal work environment. Avoid applying randomly with vague terms; instead, develop a clear, intentional strategy to save time, reduce stress, and improve outcomes. Ask yourself:

- What kind of work energizes me?
- What skills do I want to use or develop?
- What type of work environment or company culture would I thrive in?

If you're unsure, use the [Major and Career Exploration Guide](#), take self-assessments in [Focus2](#), and explore [What Can I Do With This Major?](#) For more guidance, connect with a [Career Counselor](#).

Identify Your Ideal Work Environment

Step 1: Understand Common Work Environments

Once you've identified your career goals, the next step is to consider the work setting that will align with your values, personality, and work style. Consider the common work environments below and reflect on where you could most see yourself working.

Work Environment	Description
<i>Nonprofit</i>	Mission-driven organizations focused on social impact and community collaboration
<i>Government</i>	Public sector roles with structured systems and a focus on serving the public
<i>Healthcare</i>	Patient care, research, or administrative roles in fast-paced, team-oriented environments
<i>Education</i>	Teaching, student support, administration, or program coordination in schools, colleges, etc.
<i>Technology & Startups</i>	Innovative, fast-paced environments with flexibility and a creative culture
<i>Industrial/Manufacturing</i>	Hands-on or process-focused work in production, logistics, or operations

Example: A marketing internship at a tech startup may involve innovation, rapid changes, and flexibility, while one at a nonprofit might focus on community outreach and mission-driven storytelling. Knowing your fit helps you make better choices.

Identify Your Ideal Work Environment (continued)

Step 2: Determine Your Best Fit

Ask yourself:

- Do I prefer fast-paced or structured environments?
- Do I prefer working independently or collaboratively?
- What causes or values matter most to me in a workplace?

If you're unsure, use these tools:

- [Focus2](#) – Take self-assessments to identify your interests and personality preferences.
- [What Can I Do With This Major?](#) – Explore industries aligned with your major.

Step 3: Use Labor Market Data

Use [Labor Market Insights](#) to search for in-demand roles, projected job growth, and top employers. Filter by location (e.g. San Jose, CA) to see what's relevant to where you want to work.

Step 4: Identify Specific Companies

Tool	Best For
Labor Market Insights	Finding companies aligned with your major or skills; shows real employers hiring in your region; integrates labor market data
LinkedIn SJSU Alumni Tool	Discovering where SJSU alumni work; filter by major, industry, and employer to explore career paths
SJSU Handshake	Finding internships and jobs posted by employers seeking SJSU students
Glassdoor & Indeed	Researching company culture and salaries, reading company reviews, and browsing open roles
GenAI	Finding targeted opportunities and companies Sample prompts: • List tech startups in California offering internships in [insert field] • What entry-level job titles do SJSU alumni in [insert major] hold?

Pro Tip: Apply early—within two weeks of the job posting (ideally within the first 72 hours)—to increase visibility before roles fill, especially with AI-driven hiring systems ([GetJobs-AI](#), 2024).

Prepare to Apply

Save time and feel confident about the application process by following this preparation checklist.

Application Materials

- ☐ Tailored resume for a specific job or internship, refer to the [Resume and Cover Letter Guide](#).
- ☐ Targeted cover letter highlighting your fit for the role and organization
- ☐ Checked resume using [VMock](#) online review tool
- ☐ Consider industry-specific requirements. For example:
 - ☐ Government jobs: Resume formatted per [USAJobs](#) guidelines
 - ☐ Creative fields: Portfolio or work samples prepared

Online Presence

- ☐ LinkedIn Profile completed, polished, and keyword-optimized. Reference the [Utilizing LinkedIn Guide](#) and [LinkedIn for Students](#)
- ☐ (Optional) Personal Website or online portfolio created (e.g., Adobe Portfolio)

Interview Preparation

- ☐ Reviewed the [Interviewing Guide](#) for basics, common questions, and attire tips
- ☐ Practiced responses using [Big Interview](#) (industry-specific mock interviews)
- ☐ Prepared thoughtful questions to ask the interviewer

Target Your Search

Once you know what you're looking for and have your materials ready, you can begin a targeted search.

Identify Top Employers

Research employers in your field and location of interest using tools like [Labor Market Insights](#) to discover current hiring trends, in-demand skills, and common job titles by state or county, and visit employer career pages for opportunities.

Research Entry-Level Titles

Know which roles match your qualifications and understand the typical entry-level titles for your field. For example, a new Business Administration graduate with a concentration in Management might target "Management Trainee" over "Manager", which requires more years of leadership experience. Use the [SJSU Alumni LinkedIn](#) page and filter by major to see where graduates work and what titles they hold. Connect with professionals in your field for insights, see our [Utilizing LinkedIn Guide](#) (page 6) for a connection request template.

Explore Job Boards

Use a range of different job boards to maximize and expand your search. Start with [SJSU Handshake](#) for:

- On-campus and federal work-study jobs
- Internships with employers seeking SJSU students
- Part-time or full-time roles
- Career fairs and employer information sessions

Check our [On-Campus & Federal Work-Study](#) page for a list of other on-campus employers that recruit outside of SJSU Handshake. Please note that many on-campus departments hire before the semester begins, so apply early.

Explore more opportunities through these job boards:

- [Indeed.com](#)
- [LinkedIn.com](#)
- [Glassdoor.com](#)
- [Idealist.org](#) (for nonprofit, social impact, and public sector roles)

Pro Tip: Professional associations often have industry-specific job boards on their websites. Set up profiles and email alerts for each job board to get notified and apply quickly when new jobs are posted.

Target Your Search (continued)

Industry-Specific Job Boards

In addition to general boards, you should also explore industry-specific job boards to target opportunities in your field. Below are a few recommendations.

Industry	Best For
<i>Technology & Engineering</i>	SJSU Handshake, LinkedIn, Dice, Wellfound (formerly AngelList), Built In, GitHub Careers
<i>Business & Finance</i>	SJSU Handshake, LinkedIn, Indeed, eFinancialCareers, WayUp
<i>Creative & Design</i>	Behance, Dribbble, The Dots, Coroflot
<i>Non-Profit & Public Sector</i>	SJSU Handshake, Idealist, USAJobs, Devex, GovernmentJobs
<i>Education</i>	SJSU Handshake, EdJoin, HigherEdJobs, ChronicleVital
<i>Healthcare & Human Services</i>	SJSU Handshake, Health eCareers, PublicHealthJobs, The Social Service Job Site
<i>Media & Communications</i>	Media Bistro, JournalismJobs, PRSA Jobcenter, LinkedIn
<i>Startups</i>	SJSU Handshake, Wellfound (formerly AngelList), Built In, Y Combinator Startup Jobs

Expand How You Build Experience

Remember that internships and part-time jobs are not the only ways to gain relevant experience. Consider:

- Volunteering
- Participating in a [Recognized Student Organization](#)
- Engaging in research or [service learning](#)
- Joining leadership programs
- Completing a virtual job simulation in [Forage](#)

Refer to our [Build Experience Guide](#) (pages 8-10) for a list of ideas, resources, and tips on ways to build experience on and off campus.

Networking: Informational Interviews

Networking is the process of building and maintaining relationships with people who can share information, advice, and opportunities. It's not just about *getting a job*—it's about learning, exchanging ideas, and staying connected over time. **One of the best ways to network is to conduct an informational interview.** An informational interview is a short, informal meeting (in person or virtual) with someone who works in a field, company, or role you're curious about. The goal is to learn—not to ask for a job.

How to Set Up an Informational Interview

Step	What to Do
1. <i>Clarify Your Goal</i>	Before reaching out, ask yourself: What do I want to learn? Why am I interested in this person's role, field, or company?
2. <i>Find the Right Person</i>	Ask for referrals from people you know. Use platforms introduced earlier—your personal network, SJSU² , or the LinkedIn Alumni Tool —to connect with alumni and professionals in your field
3. <i>Send an Outreach Email</i>	• Who you are • Why you want to connect • What you have in common

Sample Outreach Message

Hi [Name],

My name is [Your Name], and I'm a [class year] studying [your major] at SJSU. I saw that you work as a [job title] at [organization], and I'm really interested in learning more about your path. Would you be open to a brief 20-minute conversation (phone or Zoom) to share your experience? I'd be grateful for your time.

Thank you!

Tip: Be polite and specific. Not everyone will respond—and that's okay! If you send 10 messages, you might hear back from 2.

Networking: Informational Interviews (continued)

Preparing for the Conversation

Thorough research is key! Before your meeting, research the person's professional background (LinkedIn, company website), and the industry. This allows you to ask more specific and insightful questions.

Prepare questions ahead of time. Aim for questions that cannot easily be answered with a quick online search, demonstrating your genuine interest. Below are some suggested questions.

- How did you get into your current role or field?
- What does a typical day look like?
- What do you enjoy most—and what's most challenging?
- What skills are most important now in your field and in the future?
- How was your transition from college to career?
- What professional groups or resources do you recommend?
- What trends are shaping your industry?

On the Day of the Informational Interview

- Be on time (or a few minutes early)
- Dress professionally—even for virtual meetings
- Virtual: Be in a quiet, well-lit space with good Wi-Fi
- End by thanking them and, if appropriate, ask:
"Are you aware of any opportunities or organizations I should explore?" This opens the door without putting pressure on the other person.

Following Up

Always send a thank-you email within 24 hours.

Sample Thank-You Message

Dear [Name],

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. I especially appreciated your insight on [specific point] and your advice about [specific topic]. It was incredibly helpful as I explore [your career interest]. I hope to stay in touch!

Sincerely,

[Your Name]

If they suggested follow-up tasks (e.g., reading an article, connecting with someone else), check back in later and share your progress. This shows initiative and keeps the connection alive.

Networking: Informational Interviews (continued)

Growing Your Connections Over Time

Building a network isn't just about one-time meetings—it's about staying connected in authentic ways. Try the ideas below.

Relationship-Building Tip	Why it Matters
<i>Share helpful articles or job leads</i>	Adds value without asking for anything
<i>Congratulate them on milestones</i>	Shows you're paying attention
<i>Check in periodically</i>	Keeps the connection warm without an agenda
<i>Ask for their opinion</i>	Shows you appreciate and respect them
<i>Engage on LinkedIn</i>	Like, comment, or share their posts to stay visible

Opportunities to Network

Setting	Examples & Tips	Links
<i>SJSU Career Center Events</i>	Career fairs, employer information sessions, employer career Treks, career workshops	Career Center Events
<i>On Campus</i>	Classes, Recognized Student Organizations (RSOs), clubs	Recognized Student Organizations
<i>Industry Events</i>	Professional associations & conferences related to your field	CareerOneStop - Professional Association Finder

Next: *How to craft your professional pitch, maximize career fair connections, and build authentic relationships that go beyond a single conversation.*

Preparing Your Professional Pitch

A professional pitch—also known as an elevator pitch or conversation starter—is a 60-second introduction that helps you confidently introduce yourself to professionals. You might use it at career fairs, information sessions, networking events, or even club meetings.

Your pitch should briefly highlight:

- Who you are
- What you're studying or involved in
- A skill, project, or experience that shows your strengths
- What you're looking for and why

The goal is to spark interest and invite further conversation.

Example: *"Hi, I'm Sammy, a rising senior and student leader in the Public Health Honor Society at SJSU. I'm majoring in Public Health, and one of my favorite projects was analyzing survey data on sleep and fast food trends using Qualtrics. I found a clear connection between sleep deprivation and unhealthy eating habits. I'm graduating in June and looking for a full-time role where I can apply my love of research and data to promote healthy behavior change. I'd love to hear more about..."*

See more examples in this article: [How to Prepare Your Virtual Career Fair "Elevator Pitch"](#)

Start brainstorming key points to bring up in a conversation with an employer or professional, and then write your professional pitch using some of the key points below.

1. **Major**

2. **Interests**

3. **Desired Position**

4. **Experience**

5. **Projects**

6. **How Your Background and Future Goals Fit the Organization's Needs**

7. **Professional Pitch**

Put Your Pitch to Work at Career Fairs

Career fairs are a great opportunity to meet multiple employers in one place and make a strong first impression. Follow the tips below to navigate career fairs with confidence.

1. Research Employers on SJSU Handshake

1. Log in → Click **Events** → **Career fairs at your school** → select your career fair → **Employers** tab
2. Filter by **Location**, **Work Authorization** (e.g., OPT/CPT), **Industry**, **Job Type**, **Employment Type**, **School Year**, and/or **Major** to refine the list.
3. Pick 5–10 employers, based on your research, to connect with at the fair.

2. Before the Fair

- **Join our Job Fair Success workshop:** SJSU Handshake → Events → Career Center guidance events
- **Polish your resume:** Create a general version as well as one tailored for top employers.
- **Perfect your pitch:** Write and rehearse a 30- to 60-second introduction.
- **Prepare smart questions:** Go beyond what's on the employer's website.
- **Optimize your profile:** Update Handshake and LinkedIn profiles with recent information.
- **Get ready:** Professional attire, several resume copies, a calendar, and your student ID.

3. During the Fair

- **Warm-up:** Start with non-target employers to practice your pitch and build confidence.
- **Mind your etiquette:** Wait politely in line, keep chats to ~5 minutes and avoid pressuring recruiters after the fair.
- **Engage professionally:** Smile, firm handshake, deliver your pitch, and offer your resume.

4. After the Fair

- **Follow up promptly:** Send personalized thank-you emails to reaffirm your interest.
- **Track applications:** Follow employer application instructions, and monitor Handshake updates.
- **Make a decision:** Accept one offer, withdraw from any others, and prepare for your future role.

Set a Plan and Stay Organized

You’ve probably heard the saying, “*Finding a job is a job in itself*”—and it’s true. It often takes **21–80 applications to land one offer** ([Zippia](#), 2023). The key is to focus on quality over quantity. A well-tailored application stands out more than dozens of generic ones.

Balancing a job or internship search with your classes, work, and life responsibilities can be challenging—but manageable with a clear plan. Just like any big project, the first steps are to **set realistic goals, manage your time, and stay organized**.

Below are some questions to consider as you set realistic goals for yourself.

Question	Tips
<i>How much time can you dedicate each week?</i>	Aim for 10–20 hours/week if you’re actively searching. Block out time in your planner.
<i>How often will you check for new job postings?</i>	Check 1–2 times/week. Bookmark your favorite job boards in a folder.
<i>How many applications will you submit per week?</i>	Set a goal of about 2–5 applications/week and adjust for quality over quantity.
<i>How will you include networking in your routine?</i>	Schedule informational interviews and attend events weekly. Reach out to 3-5 people/week.
<i>How will you stay motivated and accountable?</i>	Write down and display your goals. Ask a friend or mentor to check in with you. Reward progress!

Application Tracking Worksheet

Once you start applying to positions, it's helpful to track details of your job search. Feel free to use the sheet below or create your own.

Employer	Job Title	Posting Link	Application Deadline	Date Applied	Status	Follow Up / Notes

Next Steps

Application Follow Up

- Wait about **3 weeks after the application deadline** before following up (unless the job posting says otherwise).
- If the posting includes a contact or you know the hiring manager’s name, send a polite email expressing continued interest and asking about the hiring timeline.
- If you don’t hear back after a follow-up, don’t continue contacting them. Some employers may have already hired or are simply delayed. Focus your energy on new applications.

Stay Motivated

Staying motivated during a job or internship search can be tough—especially if you’ve been job hunting or unemployed for a while. Frustration or disappointment is natural, but maintaining a positive mindset is key to sustaining your momentum. Use the tips below to stay focused and optimistic.

Tip	Why it Helps
<i>Use positive self-talk</i>	Focus on your wins. Celebrate interviews or strong applications—even if you don’t get the job.
<i>Don’t let rejection stop you</i>	Reflect, adjust your strategy, and keep going. Practice makes progress.
<i>Stick to your plan</i>	Job searches take time—just like fitness goals, results come with consistency.
<i>Have a backup plan</i>	If Plan A isn’t working, consider temporary or related roles that can still get you closer to your goals.
<i>Talk to your career counselor</i>	They can help you troubleshoot, find new strategies, and stay encouraged. Make an appointment with your career counselor liaison.

Reflect

Take some time to celebrate your successes and reflect on your experience. Consider the following questions:

- What strategies or resources worked particularly well for you?
- Are there areas you want to improve on for future searches?
- What do you want to remember the next time you are looking for a new opportunity?
- What did you learn about yourself, the job market, and/or search strategies during this experience?

If any people offered you advice or assistance in your search, be sure to thank them for their support. Finally, for tips on preparing for interviews and negotiating an offer, refer to our [Interviewing Guide](#).